



from Srinagar and eight from Jammu. We never believed in such a system. **There's only one quota and that was merit. We saw that a system had to be set in place. We formed a Cricket Advisory Committee (CAC), imported red soil from Maharashtra, conducted all camps with SG and Kookaburra balls.** Now, there are about 10 to 12 red-soil wickets and 10 to 12 black-soil wickets.

"Then, we hunted for talent. We clubbed three districts into a zone and sent all our selectors, coaches and staff to pick up the best possible talent. Then we started grooming them. So, a lot has been done," the 46-year-old added.

However, it would be remiss not to acknowledge the role of former cricketers and coaches who helped keep alive the interest in the game. It was Parvez Rasool who broke the glass ceiling first when he became the first J&K cricketer to play for India in June 2014.

Driving force: Paras Dogra and Auqib Nabi, the chief architects of J&K's successful campaign.

He, along with fellow J&K captains such as Samiullah Beigh, toiled long and hard as J&K reached the last eight in 2013-14 and 2019-20 as well. From the legendary Bishen Singh Bedi to Sunil Joshi to Irfan Pathan, all have coached and mentored players for the better. As Rasool rightly told *Sportstar* ahead of the title-decider, the recent highs were all "part of the same process".

"I think this is a very big achievement for each and every individual from J&K," said Samad. "Not only the players and the staff, but also the people, youngsters and aspiring cricketers. People will now be more interested in cricket and they will try to practise and come in for the trials as well. I think this is going to change the lives of many."

Top performers



Most runs

R. Smaran (Karnataka)

Innings: 14 | Runs: 950 | Average: 86.36 | HS: 227* | 100/50: 4/3

Ayush Doseja (Delhi)

Innings: 12 | Runs: 949 | Average: 105.44 | HS: 209 | 100/50: 4/5

Sanat Sangwan (Delhi)

Innings: 14 | Runs: 828 | Average: 69.00 | HS: 211* | 100/50: 3/3

Most wickets

Auqib Nabi (Jammu & Kashmir)

Innings: 17 | Wickets: 60 | Average: 12.56 | Best: 7/24 | 5WI: 7

Mayank Mishra (Uttarakhand)

Innings: 16 | Wickets: 59 | Average: 17.69 | Best: 17.69 | 5WI: 4

Shreyas Gopal (Karnataka)

Innings: 19 | Wickets: 48 | Average: 23.14 | Best: 8/110 | 5WI: 2